

C11 CIVIC ENGAGEMENT | O (MAX : 2 PT)

Intent : Encourage individuals to become actively involved in and connected to the surrounding community through volunteerism, public spaces and community programming.

Summary : This WELL feature requires a commitment to civic engagement through charitable activities, designated public spaces and community engagement programs.

Issue : Millennials represent an increasingly large segment of the workforce, yet surveys find that one in four millennials plan to quit their current employer in the next year due to the perception that their company's goals do not extend beyond profit.¹ Companies that do not demonstrate stronger social values through civic engagement opportunities, like community volunteering, have been shown to experience lower employee morale, engagement and productivity.² Moreover, research in the U.S. reveals a decline in community social support and relations, with people who feel disconnected from their community encountering more mental health issues than those with a strong community connection.³⁻⁵

Solutions : It is essential for companies to consider the link between corporate social reputation and talent attraction.⁶ Scheduling volunteer opportunities, providing paid volunteer time off, matching employee charitable contributions and working with local community organizations can foster a culture of social responsibility, enhance employee retention and make a positive contribution to the local community.^{1,2,7,8} There are a variety of ways to increase opportunities for civic engagement and establish a culture of social responsibility. Moreover, projects that provide public use spaces and community programming can encourage social interaction and cohesion, community empowerment and collective feelings of ownership, reducing community health risks like stress, depression, heart disease, stroke and chronic disease and improving physical and mental health, happiness and healthy behaviors.^{3,5,9-12}

PART 1 PROMOTE COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT (MAX : 1 PT)

For All Spaces:

The project or organization has a policy that meets at least two of the following requirements:

- All eligible employees are given the option to take paid time off to participate in volunteer activities for at least the equivalent of two workdays annually (separate from vacation, sick or other generally allocated paid time off).
- A list of local volunteer opportunities is provided to all employees, with at least one suitable opportunity per month and at least eight hours organized by the employer with a registered charity or non-profit per year.
- Employer matches employee's contributions to a registered charity or non-profit of employee's choice, up to a maximum annual amount defined by the employer.
- At least one community engagement program (e.g. events, talks, workshops, trainings or other public engagement intended to promote education, play, physical activity, social connection and/or well-being) at no cost to the public on a quarterly basis on- or off-site.^{3,13,14}

PART 2 PROVIDE COMMUNITY SPACE (MAX : 1 PT)

For All Spaces:

Option 1: Public space

The project designates outdoor or indoor space for public use at no cost that meets the following requirements:

- At least 186 m².¹⁵
- Open at all times, unless closed for security purposes (e.g., during nighttime hours) or temporarily for special events.¹⁵
- Signage or other communication clearly indicates hours the space is open and the designation for public use.¹⁵
- Provides quality seating areas and is easily navigable for individuals of all abilities.^{15,16}

OR

Option 2: Community event space

One or more indoor or outdoor spaces within the project boundary are open for public convenings (e.g., local community groups, student clubs, non-profit organizations) at no cost that meets the following requirements:

- Has the capacity to hold to least 10 people.
- Is available for meetings and/or events (e.g., pop-up health services, community meetings) on a weekly basis, at a minimum.^{3,13,14}

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